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KASHMIR

# The 'Almost' Independents

By Moazum Mohammad

accusations of being the BJP's B-team. That suspicion has gained ground as the saffron side has fielded only 19 candidates for the 47 seats in the Valley, concentrating instead on Hindu-majority Jammu. When the time comes for government formation, the BJP hopes it can call on these Independents to make up the numbers. That impression seems to have filtered into public consciousness as well and translated into less-than-expected crowds at rallies of Independents. A 'rally' in Kulgam's Devsar constituency, for instance, saw tepid turnout, with only a dozen people surrounding the Independent candidate supported by Rashid's party.

The barbs hitting home, the 58-year-old Rashid is now trying to invert the accusation. "I have irrefutable evidence that Omar Abdullah and Sajad Lone have ganged up to defeat Engineer Rashid in north Kashmir and elsewhere. Can Omar Abdullah now tell us which is the BJP's B-team?" he asks.

But even as the Independents struggle to shake off the BJP's shadow, they are also queering the pitch for established players. Jamaat-supported Independent candidate Sayar Reshi, for instance, is pitted against Communist candidate M.Y. Tarigami, from the National Conference-Congress alliance, in Kulgam, a seat he has been winning since 1996. Tarigami is clear that the BJP has fielded these proxies to reach the 46-seat mark for government formation. "Even now, the BJP knows it won't get any seat here," he says. "The timing of Engineer Rashid's release and his support to Independent candidates and the Jamaat is aimed at splitting the vote."

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- **346, or 40% of the 873 candidates this time, are contesting on their own**
- **They hope for better prospects in the fluid scenario after the abrogation of Article 370**
- **Critics, though, accuse them of being fielded to queer the pitch in the Muslim-majority Valley and help the BJP**

Meanwhile, even as Engineer Rashid has been let out to campaign, 38-year-old Sarjan Ahmad Wagay, who is contesting from Beerwah and Ganderbal, from where Omar Abdullah, too, is contesting, remains in jail as does his wife. His 16-year-old daughter Sugra Barkati is running his campaign, going from village to village, lamenting her parents' plight and singing eulogies, and earning sympathy and candies in return. All of which has triggered panic in Budgam panchayat's district development council chairman Nazir Khan, whose father represented Beerwah in the legislative assembly. Backed by Rashid, he is targeting Sugra, asking "how can a young girl roam around with strange men?"

A third set of Independents are political heavyweights who have shunned their parties. These include ex-PDP patron and deputy CM Muzaffar Hussain Baig, who is contesting from Baramulla; former Congress minister Taj Mohi-ud-din from Uri, ex-J&K Apni Party legislators Usman Majeed from Bandipora, Noor Mohammad Sheikh from Shalteng and former Srinagar Municipal Corporation mayor Junaid Azim Mattu from Zadibal.

With the abrogation of Article 370 etching a new political reality on the J&K landscape, many of these leaders are seeing the Independent route for relevance given the likelihood of a fractured mandate. Says political analyst Noor Ahmad Baba, "With their future uncertain, many, including some legislators, are contesting as Independents." But their hopes may not necessarily come to fruition. In 2014, of the 274 Independents, only three won; 267 forfeited their deposits. ■